

May 15<sup>th</sup>, 2026  
Week 20  
Volume 282, Issue 1235



*"There are only two options regarding commitment. You're either in or you're out.  
There's no such thing as life in-between."*

- Kathy Collins

## Highlights:

- Stalemate locks.

- Brent rebounds.

- BDI breaks 3,000.

- Backlog stays.

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## -- MARKET COMMENTARY --

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### STALEMATE HOLDS, BACKLOG STAYS

The Week 19 thesis that diplomatic motion would not release tonnage in time has been confirmed. The one-page MoU that drove Brent from USD 126 to USD 96 in five sessions has stalled, with President Trump publicly rejecting Iran's counter-proposal on May 12, describing the April 8 ceasefire as being on "life support," and warning of renewed military action at a higher level of intensity. Brent has since rallied 7.5% over three sessions to USD 107.77, while WTI has moved back to USD 102.18. Both contracts remain roughly 45% above their February 28 levels, and the war premium that appeared to be cracking in Week 19 has instead re-formed.

Saudi Aramco CEO Amin Nasser warned that the oil market will not normalise until 2027 if the Strait of Hormuz remains closed beyond mid-June, while the IEA confirmed that global oil inventories fell at a record 4 million barrels per day through March and April. Even under a more constructive diplomatic scenario, the market remains heavily undersupplied through October, with Saudi output at its lowest level since 1990. Fresh U.S. sanctions on entities involved in Iranian oil sales to China added another layer of friction as President Trump and President Xi met in Beijing this week, with Hormuz, Iranian oil flows, Taiwan, trade, and energy security among the issues on the agenda. The diplomatic track has not collapsed, but it has stopped advancing.

Freight has continued the rally that defined Week 19. The Baltic Dry Index broke through 3,000 on May 7 before consolidating, while the Baltic Capesize Index reached 5,139 and daily Capesize earnings moved above USD 43,000. Panamax earnings also firmed, with the P5TC advancing from USD 18,490 to USD 20,099. The dry bulk earnings premium that keeps older bulkers trading rather than beached is now at its strongest level of 2026. For owners contemplating a recycling decision before the monsoon window closes, the signal remains unambiguous: keep trading.

Currency divergence has widened rather than narrowed. The Indian Rupee has breached 96 to touch a fresh all-time low, the Pakistani Rupee has firmed counterintuitively, the Turkish Lira remains pinned near record weakness, and the Bangladeshi Taka continues to hold its established band. The Dollar Index remains near 100, leaving buyers across the recycling markets with different pressures but the same basic constraint: price confidence remains difficult while supply remains absent. Detailed country reads follow on pages 2 through 5.

Approximately two weeks now separate the sub-continent from the practical closure of the monsoon window. The six-week arc from Week 15 through Week 20 has produced a market in which oil, freight, currencies, and inflation are all pointing to the same outcome: tonnage is not arriving in time. The Q1 overhang has not merely rolled into a Q2 backlog. The Q2 backlog has hardened. Bangladesh and India's April CPI prints, Iran's response to the MoU, and Aramco's mid-June Hormuz threshold all converge across the next 14 days. The window closes regardless.

## BANGLADESH



## CURRENCY HOLDS, WINDOW CLOSES

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*Currency holds.*

Bangladesh enters Week 20 with USD/BDT at approximately 122.90, fully within the 122.74 to 123.18 band that has defined the whole of Q2 to date. The Taka has not breached that range in either direction through the diplomatic whipsaw, Brent's recovery from USD 96 to USD 107, the rupee's break to a fresh record low, or the lira's stabilisation near prior record weakness. The Dollar Index remains near 100, and the central bank has continued to absorb proportional Taka pressure without a forced devaluation. Foreign exchange reserves of approximately USD 34.12 billion as of March remain the operative buffer. Local steel plate prices continue to hold in the BDT 69,100 to BDT 71,000 range, with the USD equivalent at approximately USD 562 to USD 578 per ton. The pricing position keeps Chattogram clearly above Alang and Aliaga.

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*LC pipeline runs.*

The Letter of Credit pipeline has now sustained its cleared operational status for a fifth consecutive week, with Chattogram cash buyers continuing to report file-to-fund cycles materially shorter than the February reference. The two OFAC-sanctioned VLCCs at OPL Chattogram enter their ninth week unresolved, and the heightened due diligence framework that emerged in response is now fully institutionalised across the cash buyer community. The structural friction that defined Q1 has been operationally absent for five consecutive weeks. The financial environment is now the most permissive it has been since the war opened. The compliance environment is unchanged.

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*Print pending.*

Bangladesh's April 2026 CPI release from BBS is now overdue, with the March print at 8.71% and non-food inflation at 9.09% remaining the operative reads. Pakistan's April CPI at 10.9%, up from 7.3% in March, and Turkey's at 32.37%, up from 30.87%, have established the basin war-shock benchmark. Bangladesh's print is therefore the open question: whether Taka stability through the Q2 band has insulated the consumer basket from the same energy and transport pass-through that drove the Pakistan and Turkey readings. The pre-monsoon window has tightened to approximately two weeks. Brent's recovery from USD 96 to USD 107 over the past nine days, driven by the diplomatic stalemate, has removed the May 6 hope that bunker costs were normalising. The yards still want ships. The owners still hold them. The window still closes.

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NO MARKET SALES REPORTED

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## INDIA



## RUPEE BREAKS AGAIN

USD/INR has broken to a fresh all-time low of approximately 95.71 on May 14, surpassing the May 4 record of 95.27 and extending the move from the Week 14 record of 94.42 that defined the early-conflict regime. The rupee weakened 0.74% on the session, with the week trading in a 94.26 to 95.90 range. The recovery from the May 7 close of 94.18, which had been priced on one-page MoU optimism, has now been more than fully reversed by President Trump's May 12 rejection of Iran's counter-proposal and the broader diplomatic stall. The Reserve Bank of India's intervention posture remains notably restrained. Today's move is the cleanest possible market signal that the rupee is no longer pricing any near-term Hormuz normalisation.

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*Fresh record.*

Saudi Aramco CEO Amin Nasser's May 12 statement that the oil market will not normalise until 2027 if Hormuz remains closed beyond mid-June represents the most explicit official quantification of the rebalancing horizon since the conflict opened. The IEA's confirmation that global oil inventories are falling at a record 4 million barrels per day, alongside its warning of undersupply through October even if the conflict ends next month, frames the structural transmission to India's import bill. Approximately 70% of India's crude and 90% of LPG continue to route through or near Hormuz. Brent's recovery to USD 107, the near-term closure of the diplomatic window, and the IEA's undersupply warning together leave the rupee with no near-term floor mechanism other than direct RBI intervention, which has not materialised in size.

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*Hormuz binds.*

Local steel plate prices at Alang traded in a narrowing INR 39,800 to INR 40,500 range through the week, with the USD equivalent at approximately USD 415 to USD 423 per ton at the prevailing 95.71 exchange rate. India remains the lowest-priced sub-continent destination, with the gap to Pakistan now widening to approximately USD 255 per LDT given the divergent currency moves, as the rupee weakens while the PKR firms. The compliance differentiator remains intact: more than 110 yards at Alang continue to hold valid Statements of Compliance, and the RBI's 2% to 6% inflation tolerance band for the 2026 to 2031 period remains the macro anchor. The India April CPI print, expected on May 12, has not yet appeared in consensus feeds and remains the operative watch item. The monsoon window has narrowed to approximately two weeks. The structural case for an owner to release tonnage to Alang has not improved. On the Week 20 evidence, it has weakened. The Brent rebound has not released the tonnage. The 95.71 rupee record has not released the tonnage. Nothing this week has.

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*Supply unchanged.*

## MARKET SALES REPORTED

| VESSEL NAME  | TYPE     | LDT    | REPORTED PRICE                        |
|--------------|----------|--------|---------------------------------------|
| Valaris MS-1 | Semi Sub | 28,761 | Undisclosed Price ('as is' Indonesia) |



## RUPEE FIRMS, POSITION REPAIRED

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### *Rupee firms.*

Pakistan's Week 20 has been defined by an unexpected configuration: while the Indian Rupee broke to a fresh record low at 95.71 and the Turkish Lira held near its prior record weakness of 45.24, USD/PKR firmed marginally from the Week 19 close of 279.61 to approximately 278.58 at the interbank level on May 14, with open-market quotes at 278.9 to 279.85. The PKR is now the only sub-continent currency that has not made a new low since the early-April ceasefire. This counterintuitive strengthening reflects the combination of the State Bank's 100 basis point rate hike to 11.5%, sustained remittance discipline, and the marginal narrowing of the import-cover stress that had defined the immediate post-CPI environment. The PKR has returned to operating as the most stable major currency in the basin in level terms.

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### *Hike absorbs.*

The State Bank's first rate increase in three years has now had a full operational week to transmit through the FX market, and the early evidence is supportive rather than destabilising. The April CPI print at 10.9%, up 360 basis points from 7.3% in March, with transport at plus 29.9% and housing at plus 16.8%, remains the operative inflation reading and the most consequential macro datapoint Pakistan has produced this year. Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's disclosure that the weekly oil import bill has risen from USD 300 million pre-war to USD 800 million currently quantifies the external account pressure that the SBP rate response was calibrated to absorb. The May print, due in early June, will be the test of whether the hike has materially shifted the trajectory.

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### *Position holds.*

Local steel plate prices at PKR 190,000 per ton remain unchanged from the Week 18 close, with the USD equivalent firming to approximately USD 682 per ton on the marginal PKR strengthening. Gadani's absolute pricing position remains the firmest of the year, and the gap to India has widened to approximately USD 255 per LDT, given the divergent currency moves. The Gulf proximity premium that defined Weeks 16 through 18, and narrowed in Week 19 on the CPI shock, has been substantially repaired by the rupee firming. Three HKC-certified yards remain operational, with further certifications in the pipeline. The candidate pool aligned with Gadani's capacity has not contracted. The structural position has recovered from the Week 19 narrowing, though the operational constraint remains the same: the monsoon window has narrowed to approximately two weeks, and no tonnage release has materialised in the basin.

## TURKEY



## LIRA PARKS, INFLATION CRYSTALLISED

Turkey enters Week 20 with USD/TRY at approximately 45.24, unchanged from the Week 19 record low and reflecting the Central Bank of Turkey's sustained intervention discipline through the diplomatic whipsaw and Brent rebound. The lira remains down 1.64% over the past month and 18.02% over the past 12 months. The TCMB's controlled-slide framework continues to operate as expected: prevent disorderly devaluation, accept the level. The bank held its key policy rate unchanged in April and has signalled a data-dependent posture, but the framework that requires monthly inflation prints below the rate of nominal devaluation has been undermined by the April CPI reading of 4.18% month-on-month.

*Lira parks.*

Turkey's April 2026 CPI at 32.37% year-on-year, with monthly inflation at 4.18% versus 1.94% in March, remains the operative reading and now defines the new trajectory for 2026. The three-month disinflation narrative that defined Q1 is decisively over. Independent estimates remain materially above the official series, with ENAG at 54.62% and Istanbul Chamber data at 37.68%. The TCMB's 16% year-end target is no longer reconcilable under any reasonable trajectory. The May print, due in early June, will be the first to fully reflect Brent's rebound from USD 96 to USD 107 and the diplomatic stall.

*Inflation locks.*

At USD 268 to USD 290 per LDT across vessel types, Aliaga remains structurally uncompetitive for mainstream tonnage. The lira's parking at the prior record has firmed Turkish offers in USD-equivalent terms, but not by enough to bridge the gap to Pakistan at USD 445 to USD 480 or Bangladesh at USD 460 to USD 495. Turkey's relevance this Q2 remains confined to the EU-regulated tonnage segment, where Basel Convention compliance overrides the price differential. Aliaga is operating in a different market than the sub-continent, and the diplomatic stalemate, Brent rebound, BDI break above 3,000, and rupee record do not change this structurally.

*Niche persists.*

## NO MARKET SALES REPORTED

## GMS Weekly – Market Rankings

*For Week 20 of 2026, GMS Market Rankings / Vessel indications are as below.*

| Rank | Location   | Sentiment | Dry Bulk<br>USD / LDT | Tankers<br>USD / LDT | Containers<br>USD / LDT |
|------|------------|-----------|-----------------------|----------------------|-------------------------|
| 1    | Bangladesh | Improving | 460-465 / LDT         | 480-485 / LDT        | 490-495 / LDT           |
| 2    | Pakistan   | Firming   | 445-450 / LDT         | 465-470 / LDT        | 475-480 / LDT           |
| 3    | India      | Softening | 420-425 / LDT         | 440-445 / LDT        | 450-455 / LDT           |
| 4    | Turkey     | Softening | 268-270 / LDT         | 278-280 / LDT        | 288-290 / LDT           |

## DID YOU KNOW?

- *Ship recycling carried out at Alang to date has avoided approximately 72.55 million MT of CO<sub>2</sub> emissions, which is equivalent to the entire annual CO<sub>2</sub> emissions of a country like Sri Lanka.*
- *44.4 billion kWh of energy saved through ship recycling at Alang is enough to power every household in a country like the Netherlands for more than a year.*
- *69.16 million tons of recycled steel from ships at Alang has eliminated the need for over 100 million tons of raw iron ore extraction, significantly reducing environmental disruption.*

## IMPORTANT DATES

| INDIA                     |                 |
|---------------------------|-----------------|
| BANK HOLIDAYS             | DELIVERY TIDES  |
| May 27 / 28 – Eid al-Adha | May 14 – May 22 |

| BANGLADESH                     |                           |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------|
| BANK HOLIDAYS                  | DELIVERY TIDES            |
| May 26 to May 28 – Eid al-Adha | May 16 – May 19<br>May 31 |

| BANK HOLIDAYS                  |                                                                               |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PAKISTAN                       | TURKEY                                                                        |
| May 27 to May 29 – Eid al-Adha | May 19 - Commemoration of Atatürk & Youth Day<br>May 27 / 28 – Kurban Bayramı |

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**ALANG - Port Position as of May 15, 2026**

| No. | VESSEL NAME | LDT | TYPE | STATUS |
|-----|-------------|-----|------|--------|
|-----|-------------|-----|------|--------|

No new vessels reported.

**CHATTOGRAM - Port Position as of May 15, 2026**

| No. | VESSEL NAME | LDT | TYPE | STATUS |
|-----|-------------|-----|------|--------|
|-----|-------------|-----|------|--------|

|   |                 |        |                 |                |
|---|-----------------|--------|-----------------|----------------|
| 1 | Amazing         | 7,075  | Bulk Carrier    | Arrived May 14 |
| 2 | Energia         | 19,899 | Bulk Carrier    | Arrived May 14 |
| 3 | Speed           | 10,348 | Wood Chip Cargo | Arrived May 14 |
| 4 | Gion Maru No. 8 | 485    | Cement Carrier  | Arrived May 11 |
| 5 | Frontier        | 4,241  | Ro-Ro Cargo     | Arrived May 11 |
| 6 | Jian Jie        | 1,808  | Tanker          | Arrived May 06 |

**GADANI - Port Position as of May 15, 2026**

| No. | VESSEL NAME | LDT | TYPE | STATUS |
|-----|-------------|-----|------|--------|
|-----|-------------|-----|------|--------|

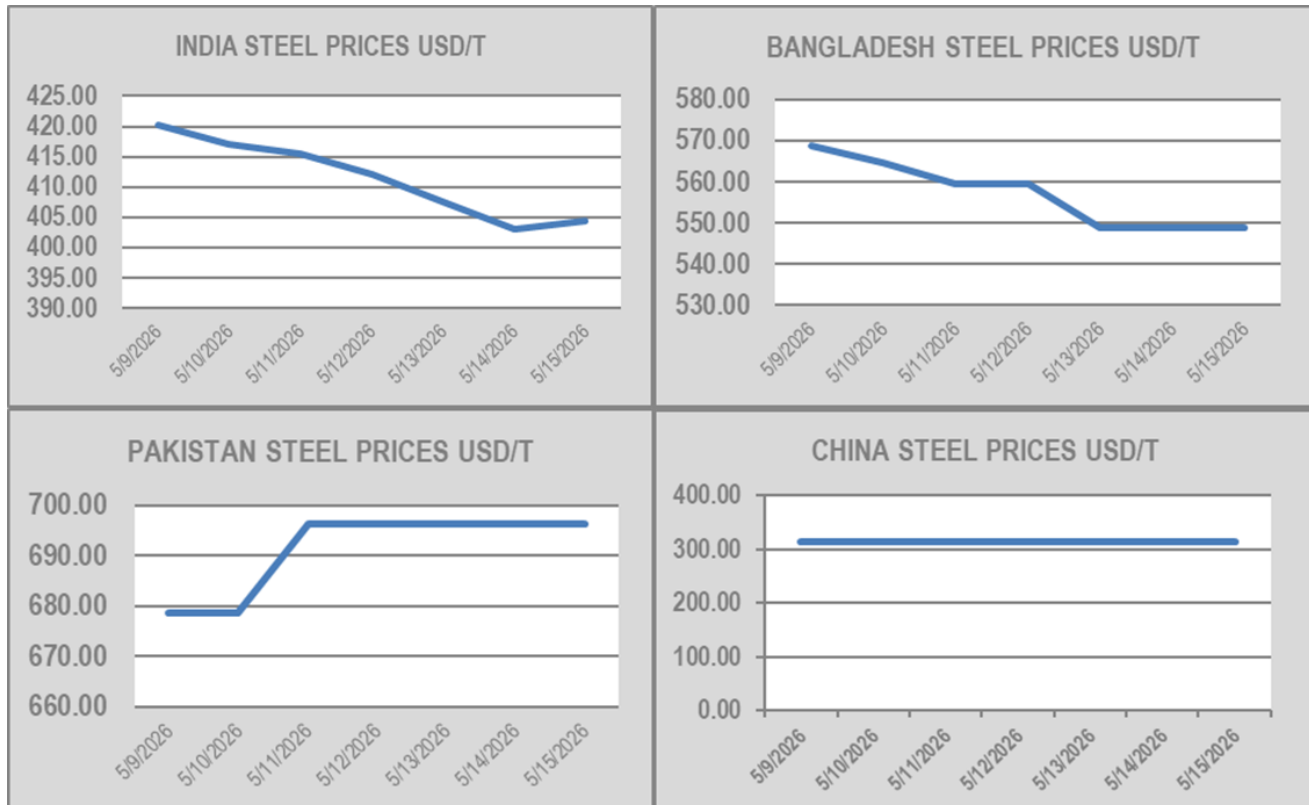
|   |           |       |        |                  |
|---|-----------|-------|--------|------------------|
| 1 | Xiong Hai | 1,659 | Tanker | Delivered May 07 |
|---|-----------|-------|--------|------------------|

|                      |              |
|----------------------|--------------|
| <b>Total Tonnage</b> | <b>1,659</b> |
|----------------------|--------------|

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| DATE      | INDIA STEEL PRICES USD/T | INDIA STEEL PRICES | PAKISTAN STEEL PRICES USD/T | PAKISTAN STEEL PRICES | BANGLADESH STEEL PRICES USD/T | BANGLADESH STEEL PRICES | CHINA STEEL PRICES USD/T |
|-----------|--------------------------|--------------------|-----------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------|
| 5/9/2026  | 420.24                   | 39,700.00          | 678.57                      | 190,000.00            | 568.72                        | 69,100.00               | 314.66                   |
| 5/10/2026 | 417.10                   | 39,700.00          | 678.57                      | 190,000.00            | 564.61                        | 68,600.00               | 314.66                   |
| 5/11/2026 | 415.49                   | 39,600.00          | 696.43                      | 195,000.00            | 559.67                        | 68,000.00               | 314.66                   |
| 5/12/2026 | 412.00                   | 39,400.00          | 696.43                      | 195,000.00            | 559.67                        | 68,000.00               | 314.66                   |
| 5/13/2026 | 407.52                   | 39,000.00          | 696.43                      | 195,000.00            | 548.97                        | 66,700.00               | 314.66                   |
| 5/14/2026 | 403.13                   | 38,600.00          | 696.43                      | 195,000.00            | 548.97                        | 66,700.00               | 314.66                   |
| 5/15/2026 | 404.38                   | 38,800.00          | 696.43                      | 195,000.00            | 548.97                        | 66,700.00               | 314.66                   |



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